

INDIA IN 2007-08

AZLAN SHAH TOURNAMENT

IPOH, Malaysia
FINISHED 3RD: Lost to Australia and Malaysia; beat China, Argentina and South Korea (for 3/4 place playoff)

CHAMPIONS CHALLENGE

ANTWERP, Belgium
FINISHED 3RD: Lost to New Zealand, Belgium, Argentina; beat England, Japan, England (for 3/4 place play-off)

ASIA CUP

CHENNAI, India
WINNERS: Beat China, Sri Lanka, South Korea, Bangladesh, Thailand, Japan, South Korea (in final)

TEST SERIES VS BELGIUM

India
INDIA WON 3-2 after leading 3-0.

TRAINING AND PRACTICE

PERTH, Australia (Feb 2008)
LOST TO Western Australia once, beat them twice; beat China twice, beat Australian Institute of Sport once.

AFP Photo: RAUL BRAVO

India playing against England in a league match in Chile



HALL OF BLAME



K.P.S. GILL: Super cop but far from super president, autocratic, dogmatic.

K. JOTHIKUMARAN: (left) Secretary, Gill's ex-ally, now at war with him.



SURESH SHARMA: (left) Gill's security officer, CRPF calls the shots now.

IHF SELECTORS: A pliable bunch of ex-players who rubber stamp teams.

Charlesworth's appointment as a sign of FIH's unnecessary interference into his affairs, Gill has been distinctly cool about the Aussie's arrival. His contact and paycheque is stuck in the offices of the Sports Authority of India (SAI) trapped between an autocrat and a bureaucrat. He may well not be the all-purpose fix for hockey's self-inflicted trauma. But to not give a man of Charlesworth's calibre even a fair chance is foolish and wasteful.

Indian hockey's troubles are only beginning: FIH says India's hosting of the 2010 World Cup is dependant on India following through on the FIH project: "Promoting Indian hockey." IHF has fallen so far that it cannot even be moved to raise a limb to accept a hand-out. Vriesman says, "The world body is still waiting for signs that things are really going to happen in India."

Former India captain Anil Aldrin

hasn't pulled out the funeral black yet but says "drastic action" is needed. "The state federations are not doing much either. As a result, the talent pool is drying up—it already has in Mumbai. Our teams are going to get weaker and weaker if nothing is done."

The Indian defeat was played out on television with due ritual as follows every major hockey reverse. The sacking of Gill was demanded, old players rolled out old grouses, and Sports Minister Mani Shankar Aiyar saying the Government could not dismiss the IHF on grounds of its autonomy under the "Olympic charter". It was no longer a fresh move in his chess game with the Indian Olympic Association but a blatant abdication of responsibility.



"The talent pool is drying up. Our teams are going to get WEAKER if drastic action is not taken soon."

ANIL ALDRIN, FORMER INDIA CAPTAIN

There is a SAI document detailing minutes of a meeting between national federations and the erstwhile sports minister Uma Bharati. They met to evolve guidelines for federation office-bearers. Bharati today admits the guidelines were not formally issued but just the mere mention of the existence of the minutes about guidelines has made many nervous.

So nervous that the document cannot be traced now and inside SAI, it has been declared missing, probably by the same department that decided that Charlesworth didn't really need to be paid. This is more than bureaucratic red tape, this is a shroud hastily being flung over a few inconvenient truths.

Underneath them all lies, Indian hockey, slowly rotting away. The despair after Chile is deeply-felt but eventually purposeless. Indian hockey can no longer be pined over like a lost love. It is a sick industry in need of restructuring. Otherwise let's roll up all the astro turf and lock up the stadiums.

with Ambresh Mishra